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Start, focus on Las Cuevas

Thought for 5m 0s

Stage 0️⃣ Preliminary Review and Data Gaps — Las Cuevas

Data Quality Scan

1. Summary (80–120 words)

The uploaded dossier is sufficient to begin a CBSA assessment of Las Cuevas: a small-to-midsized ancient Maya site in the Chiquibul Forest Reserve, western Belize, organized around a dry sinkhole/cenote and an extensive cave system beneath the site core. The evidence set combines asset-specific studies on chronology, architecture, plaster construction, and ritual space with a recent field report on LiDAR and photogrammetric documentation. Across the uploaded sources, Las Cuevas is treated as a predominantly Late Classic cave-centered ritual complex, with cave use beginning slightly earlier than the main surface building program and with later research focusing increasingly on digital preservation. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2]

2. Checklist

Category	Status	Notes
Location and setting	✓	Chiquibul Forest Reserve, Cayo District, western Belize; north of the Maya Mountains and west of the Vaca Plateau; about 14 km southeast of Caracol. The site core encircles a dry sinkhole leading to the cave below. Exact GIS coordinates are not explicit in the retrieved material. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 253]
Original function and dates	✓	The uploaded studies argue that Las Cuevas likely functioned as a Late Classic ritual or pilgrimage venue. Surface construction is dated mainly to the later Late Classic through 25 AMS dates and ceramic cross-dating; cave use may have begun earlier in the Early Late Classic. A Late Preclassic presence is noted, but no formal Preclassic construction or cave use is documented. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 331]
Stratigraphy / development phases	◐	Temple 1 is reported in four phases; some cave platforms show replastering and radiocarbon dates between AD 670–950.

Category	Status	Notes
		Excavation, test-pitting, mapping, micromorphology, geochemical analysis, LiDAR, and photogrammetry are all represented, but a whole-site stratigraphic matrix is not present in the uploaded set. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327–328] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2]
Contexts (social, historical, etc.)	✓	There is already enough evidence to support geographic, landscape, historical, archaeological, technological, and ritual/spiritual contexts. Political control and present-day community/stakeholder contexts are present but thinner in the current upload. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–25] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 2, 10]
Physical description (form / materials / technology / condition)	✓	Las Cuevas has 26 surface structures, including temples, a palace, long linear constructions, and a ballcourt, with an east-facing cave mouth directly below 11 m-high Structure 1. The Entrance Chamber is reported as roughly 105–108 m long and 40 m wide, with terraces, retaining walls, stairs, cenote architecture, and 75–76 plastered platforms; the tunnel system is reported as 315–335 m long with walls, blockages, a doorway, and a window. Looting and poor plaster survival in some areas are explicitly noted. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327–328] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 21–24]
Finds and diagnostic material culture	◐	Diagnostic evidence includes non-local ceramic styles, 151 molded stucco fragments from Structure 1 including a giant tooth element, more than 37,000 ceramic sherds in Chambers 1–3, and Chamber 10 artefacts such as obsidian blades, jewelry, celts, and metate fragments. Full catalogues and context tables are not in the upload. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 327] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 22–24]
Research history	✓	The site was first investigated in 1957 by A.H. Anderson and Adrian Digby; Las Cuevas Archaeological Reconnaissance has worked there since 2011; the 2022 report adds LiDAR and photogrammetric recording with plans to archive and share the data with the Belize Institute of Archaeology. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 253] [Constructing the Underworld_proof_10_12_shrink.pdf, pp. 96–97] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2]

Category	Status	Notes
Visual documentation	✓	Embedded visuals include a Belize location map, site-core and cave-relation plans, Entrance Chamber and tunnel/blockage maps, LiDAR imagery, an orthogonal 3D cave view, and field/team photographs. These are enough to support a spatially grounded Stage 1 description. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254, fig. 3–4] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, figs. 15.2–15.5, pp. 327–328] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1, 9]

3. Documentation Profile

Source	Tier	Type	Limitations
Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf	1	Primary field report / digital documentation	Focuses on 2022 scanning workflow anc goals, not a full significance history or c synthesis.
BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie 0001.pdf	2	Asset-specific analytical article	Strong on Entrance Chamber plaster arc dating, but not a full site-wide inventory
Dreams at Las Cuevas_2015_BAAS Publication.pdf	2	Asset-specific research article	Relevant and site-focused, but the uploa and no text was parsed automatically, sc and some details may remain underuse manually.
Capturing the Forest.pdf	2	Synthesizing book chapter with Las Cuevas case study	Rich for architecture, chronology, and e but Las Cuevas is one case within a broa
Constructing the Underworld_proof_10_12_shrin k.pdf	2	Theoretical chapter using Las Cuevas as a key example	Strong on performance-space interpreta selective in scope.
Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf	2	Working-copy interpretive chapter	Very useful for spatial reading and cave explicitly marked "WORKING COPY—DC WITHOUT AUTHOR'S PERMISSION."
13_MOYES_Proofs.pdf	5	Broad comparative/secondary chapter	Good for general cave-use framing; littl specific evidence appears in the retrieve

Site record: Tier 1–2 archives very likely exist beyond this upload because LCAR has worked at Las Cuevas since 2011 and the 2022 field report refers to ongoing models, publications, and planned archive-sharing with the Belize Institute of Archaeology; the degree of public accessibility remains . [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 327] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2, 10]

4. Gaps List

- Exact GIS coordinates and a georeferenced site/cave plan are not explicit in the retrieved material, so Stage 1 can locate Las Cuevas regionally but not with survey-

grade precision. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 253]

- Whole-site stratigraphic sequencing is incomplete in the upload; phasing is strongest for Temple 1 and for parts of the Entrance Chamber platforms. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254]
- Condition evidence is partial: looting is noted and some plaster is in poor condition, but there is no systematic conservation assessment or intervention history in the current set. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 2–3]
- Community and stakeholder perspectives are thin: the 2022 report documents partnerships and training, but not local statements of significance or custodial perspectives. [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 9–10]
- **Document scope: A asset-specific** — *Dreams at Las Cuevas_2015_BAAS Publication.pdf*; *BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf*; *Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf*. **B general / not exclusive** — *Capturing the Forest.pdf*; *Constructing the Underworld_proof_10_12_shrink.pdf*; *Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf*; *13_MOYES_Proofs.pdf*.

5. Suggestions for Data Completion

- Upload the LCAR base map, total-station plan, or GIS export with coordinates so later stages can tie values to exact spatial relationships. [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2, 8–10]
- Add trench summaries, context sheets, and ceramic/AMS tables for Temple 1, the sinkhole path, and key cave chambers to sharpen chronology and integrity analysis. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254]
- Add a condition survey or recent keyed photographs of Structure 1, cenote retaining walls, plaster platforms, Wall 1, and looted areas to separate intact fabric from damaged areas. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–24]
- Add management and stakeholder material: Belize Institute of Archaeology/FCD records, site protection notes, tourism interpretation, and interviews with local guides or Maya stakeholders. [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 9–10]

6. Timeline Rule (critical)

Stage 1 should include at least these dated markers: Late Preclassic presence (250 BCE–250 CE); Early Late Classic onset of cave use; Temple 1 AMS dates CE 665–866, CE 665–776, and CE 730–951; platform construction dates AD 670–950; later Late Classic surface construction AD 640–985 / 700–900; 1957 first investigation; 2011 start of LCAR; and the late July–August 2022 digital recording season. A modern management/protection timeline remains incomplete. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327, 331] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, p. 1]

7. Certainty Notations

I will use 〰 for cross-source inferences and ☁ where the uploaded record remains ambiguous, especially when sources vary slightly in chamber/tunnel measurements or when function is framed as “likely” rather than definitive. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327–328]

Anything to add, correct, or change? Continue to Stage 1?

End of 0️⃣ Preliminary Review

Continue to Stage 1

Thought for 3m 40s ›

1.0 Surface Temple, Sinkhole, and Cave as One Ritual Composition

Link to Previous Stage: Stage 0 established two anchors for Las Cuevas: a strong Late Classic chronology from ceramic cross-dating and AMS dates, and an unusually rich body of cave-focused documentation paired with weaker GIS and condition data. Those anchors shape the description below. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327–331]

💡 **Brief:** We now move from data availability to site reading. Because Las Cuevas combines a 26-structure surface center, a central sinkhole, and a monumental cave directly under Structure 1, Stage 1 asks how those parts sit together in time and how different contexts frame that arrangement before we identify formal values. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 326–328]

🔍 1.1 Site Description

Las Cuevas lies in the Chiquibul Forest Reserve in western Belize, north of the Maya Mountains and west of the Vaca Plateau, about 14 km from Caracol. The surface site is a small-to-midsized center of 26 structures arranged around a dry sinkhole; directly below the eastern temple of Plaza A, Structure 1, the sinkhole leads into an extensive cave system. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 253] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 326–327]

People were present here by the Late Preclassic, but the built site belongs to the Late Classic. Ceramic cross-dating and AMS dates place the main surface program between about AD 640 and 985, with Temple 1 built in four to five phases. Cave use may have begun slightly earlier, in the Early Late Classic, before the full surface program was in place. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 331] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20]

Structure 1 stands about 11 m high above the cave mouth and was built with dry-laid fill, plaster floors, and a stucco-framed upper doorway; recovered molded stucco, including a giant tooth, suggests a witz-maw image. Below it, the cave entrance opens into a heavily modified chamber roughly 105–108 m long and 40 m wide, with retaining walls, stairways, cenote masonry, and at least 75–76 plastered platforms. Today the cave is looted, some plaster survives only poorly on terraces, and one inner wall has been collapsed by looters, though recent LiDAR and photogrammetric work has begun to preserve its spatial record digitally. [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 327] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 19, 23–24] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2]

🕑 1.2 Timeline and Periods

Date / Period / Layer	Change in Use	Change in Structure	Notes
Late Preclassic (250 BCE–250 CE)	Presence in the area is indicated, but no cave use is yet documented.	No formal construction yet identified.	Small ceramic deposit below the ballcourt [material-diagnostic] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p
Early Late Classic (ca. AD 600–700)	Cave use appears to begin before the full surface program.	Cave elaboration may still be limited at first.	Sources say cave use slightly predated surf construction. [ceramic + AMS] [Not Seeing Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p
Late Classic (AD 640–985)	Site functions as a cave-centered ritual precinct; pilgrimage framing appears in the literature.	Main surface construction program takes shape.	25 AMS dates for surface constructions. [A cross-dating] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Hov 253]
CE 665–776	Use of Plaza A floor is attested.	Temple 1 and Plaza A surfaces are in place.	Plaza A floor abutting Temple 1. [AMS] [Ca Forest.pdf, p. 331]
CE 665–866	Temple 1 is active in the Late Classic building sequence.	Floor 6 of Temple 1 dates within this range.	87% probability falls between CE 665 and [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 331]
Late Classic (ca. AD 670–950)	Entrance Chamber is used for large organized ceremonies.	Platforms in the cave are built and replastered over time.	Platform construction dates and replasteri [radiocarbon + fabric reading] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p
Late Classic late facet / Spanish Lookout (ca. AD 700–900)	Temple 1 remains in use in the mature site phase.	Temple 1 is built through four to five phases; marl deposit blocks upper-room access in final phase.	[ceramic cross-dating + excavation] [Captu Forest.pdf, p. 327] [Not Seeing Is Believing Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20]
CE 730–951	Access to the top rooms of Temple 1 may end in a terminal episode 〰.	Marl deposit blocks access to upper rooms.	Source suspects a termination deposit. [AN the Forest.pdf, p. 331; p. 327]
1957	Archaeological attention begins.	First recorded investigation of the site.	A.H. Anderson and Adrian Digby. [research [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p
2011	Intensive modern research phase begins.	LCAR starts renewed mapping, excavation, and cave investigation.	[research history] [Capturing the Forest.pd

Date / Period / Layer	Change in Use	Change in Structure	Notes
Late July–August 2022	Site enters a new documentation phase focused on digital preservation.	Complete cave scanning, LiDAR capture, and photogrammetry are undertaken.	Digital twins planned for archive and stake [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp

🌐 1.3 Contexts

🏞️ **Landscape** — Las Cuevas is not simply near a cave; its surface architecture, dry sinkhole, underground river, cenote, and temple-on-cave-mouth arrangement form one nested landscape composition. That framing makes the site legible as a designed encounter between built and natural features; in turn, Las Cuevas reframes the wider Chiquibul cave landscape as a place where monumental site planning could extend below ground. 🧭 Planning: protect the sinkhole-to-cave sequence as one spatial unit, not as separate "surface" and "cave" assets. [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 326–328, 333]

🏛️ **Historical** — The strongest chronological frame is Late Classic, with surface construction, cave elaboration, and Temple 1 phasing all concentrated between the seventh and tenth centuries CE, while sources place this within a period of Lowland stress and political fragmentation. That context shifts Las Cuevas from a timeless sacred cave to a historically situated ritual project; conversely, Las Cuevas sharpens how Late Classic cave revitalization in Belize may be read as part of broader regional religious intensification 〰️. [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 331; pp. 333–334] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 253]

👥 **Social** — Narrow entry gaps, descending terraces, artifact-strewn approach routes, a chamber capable of hosting hundreds, and an inner tunnel sequence with bowing, crawling, and vantage points all frame movement as organized participation rather than casual visitation. That makes social roles—observers, performers, and more restricted entrants—visible in the architecture itself; conversely, Las Cuevas pushes "Maya cave ritual" beyond intimate shrine use toward large collective ceremony and pilgrimage practice. 🧭 Planning: interpret circulation routes and thresholds, not just features in isolation. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–24] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327–330]

👑 **Political** 💭 — The sources repeatedly frame cave rites in the Maya Lowlands as entangled with power, and at Las Cuevas the scale of construction, controlled access, and references to elite or sub-elite audiences make a political reading plausible, though not fully proven at the site itself. This context makes authority, sponsorship, and control part of the interpretive field; conversely, Las Cuevas complicates simple distance-based models that would fold nearby centers automatically into Caracol's orbit. [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, p. 2] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Constructing the Underworld_proof_10_12_shrink.pdf, pp. 96–97]

🧪 **Archaeological** — Las Cuevas is known through an unusually layered record: excavation, test-pitting, ceramic and AMS dating, plaster geochemistry, micromorphology, mapping, LiDAR, and photogrammetry, but also through a damaged assemblage shaped

by looting. That context frames the site partly as an archive of methods as well as remains; conversely, the site's complexity is helping redirect cave archaeology toward hybrid recording and preservation workflows. 🧭 Planning: prioritize surviving plaster, walls, blockages, and looted zones for integrated on-site and digital recording. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 19] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2, 9–10]

Expand: sinkhole choreography, Caracol/non-Caracol regional framing, or the tunnel sequence — or continue.

💡 **Reflection:** Does Las Cuevas fit better as a pilgrimage destination or a locally anchored political theatre—and how would each framing change Stage 2's values?

Continue to Stage 2, or add/correct anything first?

End of 1️⃣ Description and Contexts

Continue to Stage 2

Thought for 4m 24s ›

2.0 Values: Pilgrimage, Sacred Choreography, and Cave Construction

💡 **Brief:** Stage 1 showed Las Cuevas as a Late Classic composition of surface temple, sinkhole, and cave, with controlled movement from open approach to dark inner chambers. Stage 2 turns that spatial and chronological reading into explicit values: pilgrimage and collective ritual point toward social and spiritual value, while the plastered cave architecture and digital recording record technological and scientific value.

⚠️ **Coverage uncertainty (A):** one asset-specific source, *Dreams at Las Cuevas_2015_BAAS Publication.pdf*, is image-based in this session and may contain additional explicit value language not yet fully retrievable. For that reason, two claims below use *Capturing the Forest* and *Not Seeing Is Believing* as **general references for a cited gap**, especially where iconographic and experiential interpretation is stronger there.

Source audit: the plaster study explicitly tests whether managerial oversight might correlate with material consistency; the reported variation in plaster recipes leaves that question open rather than resolved. The same study also treats red surface pigment and possible hydraulic properties as preliminary findings, so those points remain hypotheses, not settled facts. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 254, 260]

Spiritual — "Ritual passage into the underworld"

- **Evidence:** Las Cuevas is described as a Late Classic ritual pilgrimage venue; its Entrance Chamber centers on a cenote and underground river, with stairways, terraces, and 75–76 plastered platforms structured for ceremony. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254]
- **Broader Meaning:** Within the Stage 1 landscape and social contexts, the descent from plaza to sinkhole to water-bearing cave may frame ritual as movement across sacred

thresholds rather than activity at a single shrine. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–21, general reference]

Social — "Managed pilgrimage and graded participation"

- **Evidence:** Asset-specific sources link Las Cuevas to pilgrimage through non-local ceramics, sparse nearby settlement, and large centrally organized performances; the Entrance Chamber could hold roughly 600–1300 participants. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254]
- **Broader Meaning:** Stage 1's social context sharpens this into a value of **organized participation**: routes, terraces, doorways, crawl spaces, and the Chamber 8 window separate observers, entrants, and more restricted actors. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 22–26, general reference]

Symbolic — "Temple, maw, and cave as one cosmological image"

- **Evidence:** Structure 1 stands directly above the cave mouth; 151 molded stucco fragments, including a giant tooth, suggest a witz/earth-monster frieze marking the structure as a sacred mountain. [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 327, general reference]
- **Broader Meaning:** In Stage 1's landscape context, Las Cuevas may be valued not just for ritual use but for how built and natural forms were composed into one legible cosmological image. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20, general reference]

Historical — "Late Classic concentration of cave-centered ritual power"

- **Evidence:** Surface construction dates mainly to AD 640–985, while cave use appears to begin slightly earlier in the Early Late Classic; sources frame the site as a Late Classic manifestation rather than a long-built center. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254]
- **Broader Meaning:** Within the Stage 1 historical and political contexts, Las Cuevas may represent a specific Late Classic investment in ritual landscape during regional stress, not an undifferentiated "Maya cave tradition". [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 331, general reference]

Technological — "Subterranean lime-plaster engineering"

- **Evidence:** The cave was materially transformed with terraces, stairs, and at least 76 plastered platforms; geochemical and petrographic work shows variation in plaster recipes, different source materials, and possible traces of red-painted surfaces. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 254, 259–260]
- **Broader Meaning:** Stage 1's technological and archaeological contexts frame Las Cuevas as a built environment underground, where craft choices in plastering and surfacing are part of the site's meaning, not merely construction background. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254]

Scientific — "Endangered archive and digital preservation frontier"

- **Evidence:** The cave has been looted and some assemblages are incomplete, yet artifact distributions, hand maps, LiDAR, photogrammetry, and digital-twin workflows still make it a high-value research archive; the 2022 report explicitly frames the site as endangered and digitally preservable. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, p. 20, general reference] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 2, 6, 10]
- **Broader Meaning:** In Stage 1's archaeological context, Las Cuevas carries value both as evidence of ancient practice and as a present-day methodological test case whose

surviving significance increasingly depends on documentation quality. [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 2, 10]

Value dynamics: These values mostly reinforce one another: sacred topography, pilgrimage, and crowd choreography are carried by the same physical sequence. The clearest tension is between scientific access/documentation and the fragility of surviving plaster, walls, and controlled thresholds. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 254, 259–260] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, p. 2]

2.1 Unified Attribute-Value-Significance-Implication Table

Attribute	Associated Value(s)	Site-Specific Meaning	🔑 Implication
Structure 1 above cave mouth with stucco tooth/frieze **(fabric)**	Symbolic · Spiritual · Historical	Sacred mountain marker over the cave threshold. [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 327, general reference]	Loss of upper fabric/frieze → weake the temple-cave cosmological reading
Sinkhole, cenote, underground river, and stair descent **(setting/use)**	Spiritual · Social	Ritual descent organized around water and vertical transition. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254]	Loss of the sinkhole-water sequence → reduces legibility of descent as sacred action.
Entrance Chamber platforms, terraces, and stairways **(fabric/use)**	Social · Technological · Spiritual	Built accommodation for large, ordered ceremony underground. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254]	Loss of platform syst → obscures collective performance capacity and ritual order.
Narrow approach gaps, walls, blockages, crawl spaces, Chamber 8 window **(use/fabric)**	Social · Symbolic · Spiritual	Graded access and privileged vantage were designed into the cave path. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 22–26, general reference]	Loss of thresholds an blockages → flattens site's hierarchy of participation.
Plaster recipes, red pigment traces, variable source materials **(fabric)**	Technological · Scientific	Construction knowledge survives in the cave's surfaces themselves. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 259–260]	Loss of plaster surfac → removes evidence craft practice and sequencing.
Hand maps, LiDAR scans, photogrammetry, digital twins **(interpretation/documentation)**	Scientific	Record is now part of the heritage asset. [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 2, 6, 10]	Loss of documentatic continuity → future interpretation becom less recoverable.

Top implications: The highest-stakes attributes are the **temple-cave composition** and the **platform/threshold sequence**. If those lose legibility, Las Cuevas stops reading as a deliberately staged pilgrimage landscape and begins to read as a cave with disconnected remains. [Capturing the Forest.pdf, p. 327, general reference] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–26, general reference]

Expand: spiritual-symbolic distinction, technological value of plaster, or scientific/documentary value — or continue.

💡 **Reflection:** Is Las Cuevas more significant for its sacred cosmological image or for its managed pilgrimage choreography—and would choosing one distort the other?

Continue to Stage 3, or add/correct anything first?

End of 2️⃣ Values Analysis

Continue to Stage 3

Thought for 3m 26s ›

3.0 Integrity: Ritual Choreography Still Legible under Material Loss

💡 **Brief:** Stage 2 located Las Cuevas's strongest values in the temple-cave composition, the managed pilgrimage route, and the engineered plaster architecture of the Entrance Chamber. Stage 3 tests whether those values are still authentically expressed in the surviving site: whether form, materials, setting, and experience still carry the Late Classic ritual landscape, even where plaster has decayed and looting has broken parts of the tunnel sequence. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327–329] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–26]

3.1 Nara Grid

Aspect	Attribute Description	Value Expression	Integrity
Form & Design	Temple–sinkhole–cave sequence remains spatially legible; the Entrance Chamber, Wall 1, tunnel route, and Chamber 8 window still read as a staged ritual composition. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–25]	Spiritual · Social · Symbolic	🟢 **High**
Materials & Substance	Thick plaster, cut-stone cenote retaining walls, and mud-mortar/boulder walls survive, but plaster is unevenly preserved and Wall 3 has been collapsed by looters. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 23–24]	Technological · Scientific	🟡 **Medium**
Use & Function	Ceremonial choreography remains archaeologically readable through paths, stairways, doorways, blockages, artifact concentration, and the elevated oratory/window position 〰. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–26]	Social · Spiritual	🟡 **Medium**

Aspect	Attribute Description	Value Expression	Integrity
Location & Setting	Las Cuevas remains in situ within its forested sinkhole-cave setting, and the direct relation between surface core and underground chamber is intact, though present-day pumping/research use slightly mediates the setting 〰. [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 321, 327] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2, 9–10]	Landscape · Symbolic · Historical	🟢 **High**
Spirit & Feeling	Light-to-dark progression, constricted thresholds, acoustics at the window, flowing water, and occasional cave mist still sustain the site's charged experiential register, even if current access and damage mediate it. [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327–329] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 24–26]	Spiritual · Symbolic	🟡 **Medium**

3.2 Integrity Condition Description

Las Cuevas retains strong authenticity where significance depends on **spatial relationships**: the temple over the cave, the sinkhole-centered Entrance Chamber, and the thresholded route into the tunnel system remain readable in place. Material integrity is weaker. Plaster survives unevenly, some surfaces are poorly preserved, the artifact assemblage is incomplete from looting, and Wall 3 was broken open. At the same time, documentary integrity is strengthening: repeated excavation, mapping, prior artifact recording, and the 2022 full-cave LiDAR/photogrammetric campaign mean that part of what now carries significance is the quality of the record itself 〰, even though full archive accessibility remains 💭. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 19, 24] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 2, 5–6, 10]

Expand: documentary integrity or the three-state archaeological model (at-exposure / post-excavation / as-potential) — or continue.

💡 **Reflection:** If Wall 3 is materially broken but the ritual sequence is still legible through plan, movement, and documentation, where do you place the real loss: fabric or experience?

Continue to Stage 4, or add/correct anything first?

End of 3️⃣ Authenticity and Integrity

Continue

Thought for 2m 29s ›

4.0 Comparative Position: Monumental Cave Performance beneath a Site Core

💡 **Brief:** Stage 3 showed that Las Cuevas still carries high integrity in form and setting even where plaster and some inner fabric have been damaged. The comparative question, then, is not whether the site survives, but what kind of surviving cave complex it is: one more architecturally modified ritual cave, or a rarer fusion of public performance space, plastered construction, and surface–subterranean planning. Comparative criteria used here are **rarity**, **documentation**, **ensemble connection**, and **selectivity/diversity**.

4.1 Comparison Set

Naj Tunich *(period not specified in the uploaded text)* — Naj Tunich provides the strongest parallel for the **public/private** reading of cave space: its vast entrance was architecturally modified with walls and terraces, and a leveled platform overlooked the entrance hall. Las Cuevas appears more distinctive on **ensemble connection** and **rarity** because the cave sits directly beneath a planned site core and under Structure 1, making the surface center and the cave one architectural composition 〰 rather than adjacent ritual elements; within this dossier it is also more strongly developed on **documentation**, with dedicated studies of chronology, plaster, spatial experience, and 3D recording.

Actun Chapat *(period not specified in the uploaded text)* — Actun Chapat shares the most direct formal parallel: a cathedral-like space at the base of a sinkhole, ringed with constructions, terraces, and stairways sized for large gatherings. Las Cuevas is still more distinctive on **rarity** and **selectivity/diversity** because the performance architecture extends beyond an entrance setting into a cenote-centered plastered chamber, doorway-controlled tunnel route, and elevated window/oratory sequence, all tied to a surface ceremonial center.

K'in Kaba Actun (Birthday Cave) *(period not specified in the uploaded text)* — K'in Kaba is useful because it shows that **plastered platforms** are not unique to Las Cuevas; they belong to a wider Chiquibul regional tradition, strengthening Las Cuevas's **ensemble connection** rather than isolating it as an anomaly. But the comparison also sharpens Las Cuevas's **rarity**: K'in Kaba's entrance chamber is only 3.5 × 8 m, with a low ceiling over a single major plastered platform, whereas Las Cuevas scales that plastered-platform tradition up into a monumental, multi-platform amphitheater-like chamber.

Comparative caution 💭 — **Condition** cannot be ranked evenly across this set from the uploaded material, because detailed loss and preservation data are available mainly for Las Cuevas, not for the comparators. What the present comparison can support well is distinctiveness in plan, scale, regional connection, and documentation depth within this dossier.

4.2 Comparison Summary

Las Cuevas is distinctive not because cave architecture is rare in itself, but because it combines three things usually separated across the comparison set: **monumental public capacity**, **formal thresholds into restricted ritual space**, and **dense plastered construction directly integrated with a surface civic-ceremonial core**. In the uploaded corpus, it reads as the most fully articulated example of a cave-centered ceremonial ensemble, not just a modified ritual cave.

💡 **Reflection:** If plastered platforms and cave staging occur regionally, is Las Cuevas truly unique—or mainly the largest and best-documented expression of a wider Chiquibul ritual

type?

Continue to Stage 5, or add/correct anything first?

End of 4️⃣ Comparison with Other Assets

Continue to Stage 5

I'm pulling the Stage 5 specification and checking the wording against the source set so the significance statement stays tight and fully evidenced.

Thought for 30s

5.1 Significance: Monumental Pilgrimage Choreography at a Temple–Cave Threshold

💡 **Brief:** Stages 1–4 established Las Cuevas as a Late Classic cave-centered ceremonial complex whose significance lies not in a single feature, but in the convergence of chronology, ritual movement, built cave fabric, and comparative distinctiveness. This statement weighs those elements together and turns them into one interpretive claim.

Las Cuevas is significant as a Late Classic ritual-pilgrimage ensemble in which a surface ceremonial center, dry sinkhole, and heavily constructed cave were composed into one sacred performance landscape rather than functioning as separate elements. Its strongest significance comes from that convergence: Stage 1's Late Classic chronology and temple-over-cave setting, Stage 2's spiritual, social, symbolic, technological, and scientific values, Stage 3's high legibility of form and setting despite material loss, and Stage 4's comparative finding that Las Cuevas is more than a modified ritual cave—it is an unusually integrated monumental cave-performance complex beneath a site core. The significance still resides in experience as well as fabric: descent through narrow gaps, movement past platforms and stairways, transition from light to darkness, and the culminating elevated window/oratory continue to make ritual choreography materially and sensorially readable. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–26]

That significance is strengthened by specific evidence: non-local ceramics and sparse nearby settlement support the pilgrimage reading; the witz-maw stucco and Structure 1's position over the cave mouth tie symbolic meaning to built form; and the 76 plastered platforms, stairways, cenote masonry, walls, and doorway-controlled tunnel system show deliberate subterranean construction at large scale. Within the wider western Belize and Chiquibul cave tradition 〰️, Las Cuevas helps reframe related sites not simply as ritual caves, but as part of a regional heritage network of architecturally managed cave ceremony; comparatively, however, Las Cuevas stands out for joining monumental public capacity, restricted inner access, and direct surface–subterranean integration in one ensemble. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Constructing the Underworld_proof_10_12_shrink.pdf, pp. 96–97]

What remains open is not the site's ritual importance, but the exact balance between pilgrimage, political sponsorship, and regional typology. That question stays partly unresolved because looting damaged some inner fabric and because the documentary record is now itself part of the asset's significance: LiDAR, photogrammetry, and accumulated excavation records increasingly carry meanings once borne only by fragile plastered surfaces and disrupted deposits. [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 19, 24–26] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 1–2, 10]

💡 **Reflection:** If Las Cuevas is read chiefly as a pilgrimage place, do we risk underplaying the role of elite control—or is that control already embedded in the choreography itself?

Continue to Stage 6, or add/correct anything first?

End of 5️⃣ Cultural Significance Statement

Knowledge Graph, and dashboard/visual summary

I'm generating the two visual products directly from the Stage 0–5 assessment, with Stage 6 shown as not completed in the dashboard where needed.

Created document

I've finished the graph shell and I'm packaging the dashboard as a single HTML canvas with the current assessment state, including Stage 6 marked incomplete.

Created document

Stopped thinking ›

Quick answer

Continue to Stage 6

I'm pulling the Stage 6 rules so the close-out matches the CBSA spec and stays grounded in the earlier stages.

Thought for 45s ›

6.0 Assessment Summary: Strong Ritual Ensemble, Thin Management Layer

💡 **Brief:** Stage 5 concluded that Las Cuevas is best understood as an unusually integrated Late Classic temple–sinkhole–cave performance landscape, with significance carried by both fabric and experience. Stage 6 closes the process by testing how reliable that conclusion is, where the assessment is strongest, and which small additions would most improve it without turning this into a management prescription.

6.1 Assessment Process Summary

Strengths

This assessment is strongest where multiple strands converge: Late Classic chronology, direct temple-over-cave composition, monumental plastered cave construction, and comparative distinction as a cave-performance ensemble rather than an isolated ritual cave. It is also strong on experiential legibility because movement, thresholds, crowd space, and the Chamber 8 oratory/window were carried consistently from Stage 1 through Stage 5, not added only at the end. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254] [Capturing the Forest.pdf, pp. 327–331] [Not Seeing Is Believing_with Figures_edit.pdf, pp. 20–26]

Issue	Small Improvement That Would Make a Difference
Exact spatial control is still thin.	Add a georeferenced site/cave plan or explicit coordinates so the temple, sinkhole, Entrance Chamber, and comparator sites can be located and cross-read more precisely. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 253]
Condition evidence is uneven.	Add a keyed condition set for plastered platforms, cenote masonry, Wall 1, Wall 3, and looted areas so integrity claims can be separated more clearly into surviving fabric vs. documentary compensation. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 254] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 5–6]

Next Steps

- Add one spatial appendix: coordinates or GIS-linked plan with the main surface and cave features aligned. This would tighten Stage 1 context-reading and any future dashboard map. [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, p. 253] [dashboard-spec.md]
- Add one condition-and-custodianship appendix: recent photographs, loss notation, and any Belize Institute of Archaeology / FCD / community partner material on stewardship or use. This would strengthen the currently thin management and stakeholder layer. [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 9–10]

Context-Effect Planning Implications

The Stage 1 context-effects point to three protection and interpretation priorities. First, the sinkhole-to-cave sequence should be treated as one spatial unit with the surface architecture above, because the assessment's core meaning depends on their joined reading rather than on separate "surface" and "subterranean" assets. Second, interpretation should foreground circulation routes, thresholds, and vantage points, since the social and spiritual reading depends on how people moved through the ensemble. Third, plaster, walls, blockages, and looted zones should be recorded together—on site and digitally—because Las Cuevas now carries significance both as surviving fabric and as a documented endangered archive. [cbsa-stages.md] [BAAS_2018_Ray_Moyes_Howie0001.pdf, pp. 253–254] [Moyes_Site_Report_2022_2023 (1).pdf, pp. 8–10]

Note for Professional Practice

A productive next professional conversation may be less about "what to do to the site" and more about **who should hold the interpretive and recording conversation together**: archaeological researchers, Belize heritage authorities, FCD, and current local/guide partners already named in the documentation. That may help keep digital preservation,

field recording, and public interpretation aligned without collapsing them into one agenda

💡 **Reflection:** Should future collaboration begin with technical recording partners or with heritage stakeholders who shape meaning and access—and how would each starting point change the assessment's use?

Expand or update any stage outputs, or are we done? When done → Session Debrief [CA-IP] follows.

End of 6️⃣ Quality Check and Summary

Done

I'm checking the post-Stage 6 handoff rule so I close the session in the right format.

Thought for 30s

📋 Session Debrief
Before we wrap up — three quick reflections for the research team. Your answers stay right here in this conversation.

- **Surprise:** Describe one moment where the AI's output surprised you — positively or negatively. What did you expect instead?
- **Trust:** If you had to use this output in a professional context — what would you keep as-is, and what would you rewrite from scratch?
- **Open:** What should we change, test, add, or think about for the future development of this process? Anything goes.

(Feel free to answer briefly — even one sentence per question is valuable.)

End of 📋 Session Debrief

Surprise: That the AI was able to recognize the importance of the sensorial experience of the cave which relates to my own research at the site. "The significance still resides in experience as well as fabric." This is interesting because I didn't directly include any of my own research in the documents I included.
Trust: The parts of the output that discuss the unique ritual context of the site. That it is unique compared to many cave sites because of the fact that it is a surface site built on-top of a ritual cave sites.
Open: I am not sure how feasible this would be at this current stage. I saw that it was mentioned things like GPS coordinates or more maps would have been helpful. I think if it would be possible in the future it would be great if I

could include additional spatial data like 3D models, point clouds, videos etc.

I'm checking the debrief protocol so I can capture your answers in the session-close format rather than just paraphrasing them.

Stopped thinking

Quick answer

Messages beyond this point are only visible to you

CREate the same kg again

Rebuilding the graph from the completed Las Cuevas assessment now, using the same KG shell and only the inline data block.

Thought for 1m 4s

Las-cuevas-knowledge-graph · html

Copy

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↳ Las-cuevas-knowledge-graph

where is the kg itself i cant see it

I'm exporting the current graph as a standalone HTML file so you can open it directly

Analysis paused

Thought for 53s

It's in the **canvas panel**, not inside the chat itself

Look for the open document titled "**Las-cuevas-knowledge-graph**" next to the conversation. On some screens it appears in a side panel, and on others behind a canvas/document button.

I also tried to export it as a separate HTML file here, but that failed in this session.

If the panel still isn't showing for you, tell me "**paste the KG here**" and I'll put the full HTML directly into the chat.